Cobb

By Lee Blessing

Portrays Ty Cobb at 3 different stages of his life
PEACH: Intense, athletic, quick to anger – about 20
TY: Self-Important, quick to anger – about 40
MR. COBB: Bitter, quick to anger – over 70.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 7)** You think you invented me, but I invented you. You think this life you live is somehow your creation. It isn't. Everything about you started with men like me. The way you think, the world you live in – all of it shaped by men like me. At the turn of the century I took a rustic, folk-art form called baseball and applied the science of warfare to it. Fit like a damn glove. That's what you owe me. *(He suddenly stares out with surprise, and cocks his head as though listening. With a growing tone of accusation).* You're trying to forget me. Aren't you? You're trying to forget me. You're trying to forget.

INTRODUCTION

Ty Cob once said, "Baseball was one-hundred percent of my life. It is a game haunted by the spirits of its rich history. Shoeless Jo Jackson, Hank Aaron, Babe Ruth . . . In this selection, Ty Cobb, one of the game's most enigmatic players, comes back from the grave to sharpen his spikes once more . . . To play to one final crowd. Cobb by Lee Blessing

PEACH: **(Pg 8)** *(With a noticeable Southern drawl- he picks up a bat, holds it out, testing its weight)* Look at that. Baseball bat's a serious item. Now and again I think about how many times one of theses been used to kill somebody. It's a club... is what it is. People use it that way. In homes all over the nation. They club each other to death with the first thing that comes to hand. *(He suddenly slams the bat hard*

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against the bench, speaks quietly) I'm the greatest player that ever lived. Ty Cobb **(Pg 15)**... the Georgia Peach.

MR. COBB: It meant perfection. I became perfection.

PEACH: **(Pg 8)** My name's been on a lot of bats. So it's been covered in blood, I suppose -- its share of the time. *(He makes to slam the bat against the bench again, but suddenly stops, relaxes)* It's no toy. And it's no game, neither. When I was 18, my mother killed my father.

TY: Babe Ruth was an orphan, and American adopted him. My mother killed my father, and no one wants to know me. **(Pg 9)** My mother took a lover. That's what some people said. Personally I think it's a ***goddamn vicious lie***, but they said it. My father was W.H. Cobb. People called him Professor. School commissioner, newspaper editor, state senator. When he was 21 he married my mother.

PEACH: She was 12.

TY: I was playing with Augusta Tourists in the Sally League. It was 1905. One night, down in Royston, my father said that he was going out to the farm for a couple days. He took the buggy and left my mother alone in the house. She was afraid of being alone. She went to bed. Little after midnight [she] heard a noise outside her window, out on the porch roof. Someone was trying to open the window. She was all alone in the house

PEACH: There was a gun in the room. Papa kept it there, for times of danger. **(Pg 10)** She just fired. She didn't look. It could've been anybody. Outside that window, on the porch roof -- with all that broken glass --that's where my father died.

TY: He was shot in the stomach -- and in the head. My mother was arrested. Accused of voluntary manslaughter.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 11)** The son of homicide. See, a myth's got to have the right kind of start. Look at Babe Ruth. He had a beautiful myth: In a home for wayward boys from the age of seven. His folks couldn't handle him. A priest became his second

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father. Boy hero rises from nothing. What did I have? A [damn] Greek tragedy. Where the hell was my second father?

TY: **(Pg 23)** Put yourself in my place. For seven years you're the finest player in baseball. Better hitter, better runner, better fielder, better thinker than any man who's played the game. If an outfielder was slow throwing the ball in, I took an extra base. If someone got in my way, I knocked 'em down. If they blocked a base, I spiked 'em. If they wanted to fight over it, I fought 'em ... ***anyone***. That was the bargain I made with baseball. If I was destined to play a child's game all my life, at least I was going to play it like an adult. **(Pg 16-17)** They made me feel like an animal. Hell, I learned what "team" meant – it meant them against me.

MR. COBB: It was the way then. You're there to replace one of 'em – they don't take kindly to it.

TY: I was humiliated every day by players not fit to stand on the same field with me. I fought people. Blood, bruises, broken bones – people laid up for days. Careers ended. I had fights. **(Pg 19)** I fought. That's who I was. **(Pg 21)** I was someone! . . . **(Pg 23)** There's no damn dignity in the game! None! 5,000 strangers right behind you – like little kinds – Them sitting, you standing up all day. They should vileness. I can think of no other art form in which ignoramuses are expected to scream insults in your face on a daily basis.

MR. COBB: *(Subdued)* What are they thinking when they shout those things?

PEACH: **(Pg 24)** *(shouting like a fan)* Hey, Cobb! Your mother can run better 'n you!

MR: COBB: Your mother can do everything better 'n you!

TY: Your mother . . . Your mother!! YOUR MOTHER!

MR. COBB: **(Pg 23)** What's in their hearts that makes them need to pull a man down?

TY: **(Pg 24)** You bear it. As much as possible, anyway. They pick you out. They choose you alone. That more than anything is why you hate them Claude Lueker.

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Many times I ignored him. Whole games. Whole series. I shouted back, but I never crossed that railing. I held myself back.

PEACH: But then he figured out something new to say.

TY: *(Almost unable to say it)* He called me a . . . a "half-nigger."

PEACH: And up I went – over that railing1 I WENT LIKE A SHOT! His throat was big and white as the moon. I kicked him hard. Nobody could p ull me off him! And I never paused. I just kept kicking. Why? 'Cause it made me feel so right? *(to audience)* You think I was right, don't you?

TY: **(Pg 26)** Every congressman from Georgia wired me congratulations. The mayor and police chief of Atlanta both supported me. The police chief said if I hadn't done what I'd done, I'd've "lost the respect of every decent man in the country."

MR.COBB: I did not just fight people . . . I . . . loved.

PEACH: **(Pg 43)** Whenever I walked into a ballpark, it was like fallin' in love for the first time – again and again.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 26)** Who's going to remember me if they think I was a monster? They'll toss me away. They'll keep Ruth... him they'll remember for centuries. Me (*Trails off, quieter)* He's the one. He's the damn mountain.

TY: It's not easy to be dethroned. I'd already won eight straight batting titles before Ruth [even] showed up. I even led the league in homers once. Then in 1920, Ruth hit 54. *(We hear the crack of a bat, a crowd roars)* 54 home runs. No one had ever come near that. Overnight, people went crazy for home runs. They went crazy for him, too. Didn't matter that I could do ***everything*** in the game. As far as the fans were concerned, he only had to do one thing.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 27)** What exactly did Babe Ruth offer? Look at a typical trip to the plate for him. What happens? He takes a cut, hits a home run, trots his way around the base path like a big cow without a thought in his head. That's no trip around the bases.

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PEACH: I'll show you a trip around the bases. Cobb style. It starts with a few carefully-chosen words to the pitcher. Thigs like, "Hey, Rag-arm! That can't be your fastball. (picks up a bat, demonstrating)

MR. COBB: You hit a liner -- not some soft, lazy fly ball that flops into the stands someplace. No. You hit a bullet. You sizzle it past the pitcher's ear. Make him glad just to be alive.

TY: Then you run to first like **(Pg 28)** you're legging out a triple.

PEACH: Just the sight of speed can demoralize the other team.

TY: Once you're on first, you start to systematically destroy the pitcher's mind. It's not hard...

PEACH: And when he makes that little unconscious gesture that means he's going home and not to first

MR. COBB: ***You take off!***

PEACH: And that catcher sees you go, and his heart turns to cinder 'cause he knows you already got the base stole..

TY: But he know he's got to throw it anyway, so's not to look like a coward.

MR. COBB: ***No mercy for cowards!***

PEACH: **(Pg 29)** The throw's low! Safe at third. On a single. But not home yet!

MR. COBB: On the very next pitch, I take a long, walking lead off third. When the pitcher goes home so do I.

PEACH: There's no pleasure on earth like stealin' home. You've got to force your way in.

TY: If he drops the ball you're safe. You got to do ***anything***. You got to hit him... bruise him.... break his arm, his leg, and his ribs. You got to smell his blood. You got to ***put your spikes in his chest***! You got to ***score***!

PEACH: **(Pg 30)** You can bet Babe Ruth never took that trip. Or ever could. I could hit home runs. But he could never move around the bases like me. **(Pg 37)** Most hits, most runs scored, most stolen bases , most singles, most triples. Most records.

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TY: **(Pg 48)** When they opened the Hall of Fame in 1939, the first thing they put in it was a pair of shoes. My shoes. My spikes. The first symbol of baseball to enter that building. They didn't have to choose 'em. Babe Ruth had plenty of stuff lying around. But they chose my spikes because they truly knew the game.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 49)** What's it matter? Ruth ***was*** the game. You should've seen people when Babe Ruth died. Sure he died young, but still.

PEACH: The whole city of New York wept. Whole nation.

MR. COBB: When I went, I just . . . went. Good myth should go out with more than that.

PEACH: Ty Cobb died of cancer in a hospital when he was old and unconscious.

TY: The most hated man in baseball.

PEACH: My father died better than me.

TY: I was too real for myths. You couldn't sell what I was.

MR. COBB: **(Pg 50)** No man wants to be forgotten. Every man wants someone to remember. I was the quickest, meanest, smartest, fiercest . . . best . . . man to ever play the game... just remember.

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